

BRADFORD STARKE, INC.

FEDERAL PROCUREMENT PIPELINE SYSTEM

A Complete Business Development Framework for Building and Managing a Federal Contracting Pipeline from Scratch

Federal Business Development Toolkit | 2026 Edition
For Educational Use — Bradford Starke, Inc. | Not for Distribution

BLUF — BOTTOM LINE UP FRONT

The federal government awards over \$700 billion in contracts every year. Most of it goes to firms that showed up before the solicitation — not during it. This pipeline system gives you the exact framework to identify the right opportunities, build the right relationships, make disciplined bid decisions, write winning proposals, and turn every outcome — win or loss — into a competitive advantage. There are six stages. Each one has a clear entry point, a set of required actions, and a measurable exit criteria. Work the system every week. The pipeline never stops.

HOW TO USE THIS SYSTEM

This is a working document. Print it. Write on it. Bring it to every BD review meeting.

1. One opportunity per row.	Every active opportunity you are tracking gets its own row in the Intel Fields table for that stage. Never combine two opportunities in the same row.
2. Fill in every field — even if the answer is 'unknown.'	'Unknown' is data. It tells you exactly what you need to go find out before you can move this opportunity to the next stage.
3. Stage progression is earned, not assumed.	An opportunity does not move to the next stage until the Exit Criteria for the current stage is fully met. No shortcuts.
4. Your BD lead owns each opportunity.	Every opportunity must have one person's name attached to it. Shared ownership is no ownership.
5. Weekly review is not optional.	Use the Weekly BD Rhythm on the final section every single week. A pipeline that is not reviewed is a pipeline that dies.

PIPELINE HEALTH METRICS — TARGET BENCHMARKS

Use these benchmarks every Friday during your executive snapshot review. If any metric falls below target, that is your priority for next week.

CONTACTS IN PIPELINE 25+ Active COR / CO relationships being cultivated at any time	TOUCHPOINT CADENCE 30 days Maximum days between contacts with any warm lead	GO / NO-GO SCORE 70+ Minimum score required to commit proposal resources
PROPOSALS SUBMITTED 2/mo Target submission rate for an early-stage firm	WIN RATE TARGET 30% Industry benchmark for competitive federal proposals	DEBRIEF RATE 100% Request a debrief after every single loss — no exceptions

MARKET RESEARCH (Pre-Positioning)

01 Government term: Market Research / Pre-Solicitation Intelligence

This is where you find out who is buying what, how much they are spending, and when they plan to buy it again. You are not selling yet. You are studying.

KEY TOOLS & RESOURCES

- SAM.gov — search active and upcoming contract awards
- USASpending.gov — track how much an agency has spent on a specific service
- FPDS-NG (Federal Procurement Data System) — pull award history by NAICS code
- Agency Forecast of Contracting Opportunities — published annually by most agencies

REQUIRED ACTIONS THIS STAGE

- Identify 10–15 active contracts in your service area expiring within 18 months
- Note the incumbent contractor on each award
- Record the Contracting Officer (CO) and COR name if listed
- Flag any small business set-aside designations (8a, SDVOSB, WOSB, HUBZone)

INTEL TRACKING FIELDS — LOG ONE OPPORTUNITY PER ROW

AGENCY / OFFICE	CONTRACT #	INCUMBENT	EXPIRATION DATE	VALUE (\$)	SET-ASIDE TYPE	CO NAME	COR NAME

EXIT CRITERIA

You have a list of at least 5 qualified opportunities with known expiration dates and identified points of contact.

NOTES / INTEL CAPTURED THIS WEEK:

RELATIONSHIP CULTIVATION (COR / CO Engagement)

02Government term: Industry Engagement / Pre-Award Communication

This is the most underestimated phase in federal BD. Most firms skip it entirely and go straight to the proposal. That is why they lose. Relationships built before the solicitation drops are the ones that win contracts.

KEY TOOLS & RESOURCES

- Your COR Rapport Guide (Bradford Starke, Inc. — 2026 Edition)
- LinkedIn — research the COR/CO's background before any meeting
- Agency Industry Days and Small Business events — attend every one
- One-on-one capability briefings — 30 minutes, no hard pitch

REQUIRED ACTIONS THIS STAGE

- Schedule a capability briefing or informal introduction meeting
- Complete the COR Rapport Guide question set for each contact
- Log every interaction — date, what was discussed, what you learned
- Send a 24-hour follow-up email referencing something specific they said
- Set a 30-day touchpoint reminder so you never go cold

INTEL TRACKING FIELDS — LOG ONE OPPORTUNITY PER ROW

CONTACT NAME	TITLE / ROLE	AGENCY	DATE OF LAST CONTACT	KEY PAIN POINT SHARED	NEXT TOUCHPOINT DATE	BD LEAD ASSIGNED	RELATIONSHIP TEMPERATURE (COLD/WARM/HOT)

EXIT CRITERIA

You have had at least one direct conversation with the COR or CO, logged their primary pain point, and have a confirmed next touchpoint scheduled.

NOTES / INTEL CAPTURED THIS WEEK:

OPPORTUNITY QUALIFICATION (Go / No-Go Decision)

03Government term: Acquisition Strategy Review

Not every opportunity is worth chasing. Pursuing the wrong contract wastes time, money, and credibility. This phase forces a disciplined decision: Do we compete, team, or walk away?

KEY TOOLS & RESOURCES

- Go / No-Go Scorecard (see scoring matrix on next page)
- Draft Request for Information (RFI) or Sources Sought — read every word
- Teaming partner assessment — who can fill your gaps?
- Pwin (Probability of Win) estimate — be honest with yourself

REQUIRED ACTIONS THIS STAGE

- Run the Go / No-Go Scorecard — score must hit 70+ to proceed
- Assess whether you need a teaming partner to meet all requirements
- Identify any past performance gaps and plan how to address them
- Confirm your NAICS code, size standard, and set-aside eligibility
- Draft a one-paragraph win theme before writing a single proposal page

INTEL TRACKING FIELDS — LOG ONE OPPORTUNITY PER ROW

OPPORTUNITY NAME	SOLICITATION #	GO/NO-GO SCORE	PWIN ESTIMATE (%)	TEAMING PARTNER (IF ANY)	KEY GAPS IDENTIFIED	WIN THEME (1 SENTENCE)	DECISION DATE

EXIT CRITERIA

A formal Go/No-Go decision has been made, documented, and signed off by leadership. If Go — a capture plan is started immediately.

NOTES / INTEL CAPTURED THIS WEEK:

CAPTURE MANAGEMENT (Shape the Requirement)

04Government term: Pre-Proposal / Capture Phase

Capture is the work you do before the proposal is written. If you wait for the RFP to start thinking about your approach, you are already behind. The goal here is to influence what the agency asks for — legally and ethically.

KEY TOOLS & RESOURCES

- Draft RFP or Performance Work Statement (PWS) — study it line by line
- Capability Statement tailored to this specific agency and requirement
- Competitor analysis — who else is likely bidding and what are their weaknesses?
- Black Hat Review — think like the evaluator scoring your competition

REQUIRED ACTIONS THIS STAGE

- Submit questions or comments during any RFI / Sources Sought period
- Deliver a tailored capability brief to the CO or COR before RFP drops
- Identify your top three discriminators — what makes you different from every other bidder?
- Draft your technical approach outline before the RFP is even released
- Confirm pricing strategy and subcontracting plan if applicable

INTEL TRACKING FIELDS — LOG ONE OPPORTUNITY PER ROW

RFP EXPECTED DATE	EVALUATION CRITERIA (KNOWN)	TOP 3 DISCRIMINATORS	LIKELY COMPETITORS	PRICING STRATEGY	SUBCONTRACTORS (IF ANY)	CAPTURE LEAD	STATUS

EXIT CRITERIA

Your win theme is locked, your technical approach outline is drafted, and your team is assembled before the RFP is released.

NOTES / INTEL CAPTURED THIS WEEK:

PROPOSAL DEVELOPMENT (The Deliverable)

05 Government term: Request for Proposal (RFP) Response

The proposal is not where you win. It is where you confirm what you already built in phases 1 through 4. A great proposal written without capture work almost always loses to a mediocre proposal written by a team that did the relationship work.

KEY TOOLS & RESOURCES

- Proposal outline mapped directly to the RFP Section L (Instructions) and Section M (Evaluation Criteria)
- Color team review schedule — Pink Team, Red Team, Gold Team
- Past Performance write-ups — specific, quantified, and relevant
- Price-to-Win (PTW) analysis — know what the agency expects to pay

REQUIRED ACTIONS THIS STAGE

- Build a compliance matrix — every RFP requirement mapped to a proposal section
- Assign each section an owner and a hard internal deadline
- Run a Pink Team (draft review) at 50% completion
- Run a Red Team (full mock evaluation) at 90% completion
- Submit at least 24 hours before the deadline — never on the last day

INTEL TRACKING FIELDS — LOG ONE OPPORTUNITY PER ROW

RFP RELEASE DATE	PROPOSAL DUE DATE	PAGE LIMIT	VOLUME LEADS	PINK TEAM DATE	RED TEAM DATE	PRICE / COST LEAD	FINAL SUBMISSION DATE

EXIT CRITERIA

A compliant, compelling proposal has been submitted on time. All volumes delivered. Confirmation of receipt obtained.

NOTES / INTEL CAPTURED THIS WEEK:

POST-AWARD & RELATIONSHIP MAINTENANCE

06Government term: Contract Administration / Ongoing Performance

Win or lose, this phase determines your long-term position in the market. If you won — perform exceptionally and protect that COR relationship. If you lost — request a debrief. Every debrief is a free lesson on exactly what to fix next time.

KEY TOOLS & RESOURCES

- Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System (CPARS) — your permanent federal report card
- Monthly Status Reports (MSRs) — over-communicate, never under-deliver
- Debrief Request Letter — submit within 3 days of a loss notification
- Lessons Learned Log — document what worked and what did not, immediately

REQUIRED ACTIONS THIS STAGE

- If awarded: schedule a kickoff meeting within 5 business days
- If awarded: establish a weekly COR check-in cadence from day one
- If lost: request a formal debrief and bring a notepad, not excuses
- Update your past performance library with this contract's outcomes
- Begin market research for the next opportunity — the pipeline never stops

INTEL TRACKING FIELDS — LOG ONE OPPORTUNITY PER ROW

AWARD DECISION DATE	AWARD OUTCOME (WIN/LOSS)	DEBRIEF REQUESTED (Y/N)	DEBRIEF DATE	KEY LESSON LEARNED	CPARS RATING (IF AWARDED)	RECOMPETE DATE	NEXT ACTION

EXIT CRITERIA

Win: CPARS rating of Satisfactory or above. Loss: Debrief completed and lessons documented. Either way — pipeline updated.

NOTES / INTEL CAPTURED THIS WEEK:

GO / NO-GO SCORECARD — STAGE 03

Score each factor honestly. Total 70 points or above = Green Light to proceed. Below 70 = address the gap or walk away. Chasing bad opportunities is the #1 reason early-stage firms burn out their BD team.

FACTOR	QUESTION TO ASK	SCORING GUIDE	MAX PTS	YOUR SCORE
Relationship Score	Do you have a direct relationship with the COR or CO?	No contact = 0 Met once = 5 Established = 10	10	
Requirement Fit	Does this contract match your core service capabilities?	Weak fit = 0 Partial = 5 Strong fit = 15	15	
Past Performance	Do you have at least 2 directly relevant past contracts?	None = 0 One = 5 Two or more = 10	10	
Set-Aside Eligibility	Are you eligible for the set-aside type on this award?	Ineligible = 0 Eligible = 15	15	
Competitive Intel	Do you know who the likely competitors are?	No intel = 0 Some intel = 5 Full picture = 10	10	
Pricing Confidence	Can you price this competitively and still make margin?	Uncertain = 0 Confident = 10	10	
Teaming Gaps	Can you meet all requirements without a teaming partner?	Major gaps = 0 Minor gaps = 5 No gaps = 10	10	
Timeline Feasibility	Do you have the bandwidth to write a strong proposal?	Overcommitted = 0 Tight = 5 Capacity = 10	10	
TOTAL		70+ = GO Below 70 = NO-GO	100	

WEEKLY BD RHYTHM — THE 5-DAY SYSTEM

Federal BD is not a sprint. It is a discipline. This five-day rhythm keeps your pipeline moving even when you are busy on delivery.

Monday — Pipeline Audit	Pull up your full contact list. Who have you not spoken to in 30+ days? Flag them. Send a one-line check-in before the week starts. No pitch — just presence.
Tuesday — Market Scan	Spend 20 minutes on SAM.gov and USASpending.gov. Look for new Sources Sought notices, Industry Day announcements, or contract modifications on awards you are tracking.
Wednesday — Relationship Action	Schedule or confirm at least one COR/CO touchpoint this week. If you have nothing scheduled, that is your problem to solve today — not Friday.
Thursday — Proposal / Capture Work	If you are in active capture or proposal mode, Thursday is your deep-work day. No meetings before noon. Write, review, refine.
Friday — Executive Snapshot	Update your pipeline tracker. Log every contact made this week. Note every piece of intel captured. This snapshot becomes your Monday briefing next week.

WEEKLY NOTES / PIPELINE UPDATES:

KEY TERMS GLOSSARY — PLAIN LANGUAGE DEFINITIONS

Memorize these terms. You will hear them in every federal conversation. Using them correctly signals that you belong in the room.

SAM.gov	System for Award Management — the federal government's primary database for active contracts, vendor registrations, and upcoming solicitations.
FPDS-NG	Federal Procurement Data System — tracks every federal contract award. Use it to find incumbent contractors, award values, and agency spending patterns.
COR	Contracting Officer's Representative — the agency employee who monitors contractor day-to-day performance. Your most important relationship on any active contract.
CO	Contracting Officer — the only government official with legal authority to award, modify, or terminate a contract. Treat every interaction as high-stakes.
PWS	Performance Work Statement — defines what the contractor must do. Reading it before the RFP drops is how you shape the requirement in your favor.
RFP	Request for Proposal — the formal solicitation document. By the time it drops, your preparation should already be 70% complete.
CPARS	Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System — your permanent federal performance record. A single Unsatisfactory rating can disqualify you from future awards.
Pwin	Probability of Win — your internal honest estimate of your likelihood of winning a specific competition. If it is below 20%, reconsider whether to bid.
Set-Aside	A contract reserved for a specific category of business — 8(a), SDVOSB, WOSB, HUBZone, or Small Business. Eligibility is determined at registration in SAM.gov.
Capture	The business development work done before a proposal is written. Capture wins contracts. Proposals confirm them.
Debrief	A post-award meeting where the government explains why you won or lost. Mandatory to request after every loss. The feedback is free and brutally useful.
Color Teams	A structured proposal review process: Pink Team (early draft), Red Team (full mock evaluation), Gold Team (final polish). Each catches a different layer of problems.

PRO-TIP: The firms that dominate federal contracting are not the biggest or the most experienced. They are the most consistent. They work the pipeline every week, build real relationships before every solicitation, and treat every loss as tuition. Build this system into your weekly routine now — before you have contracts to manage — and you will be miles ahead of your competition when the opportunities actually arrive.